Cuba in the ’70s and ’80s, marked by schools in the countryside, Russian cartoons, illegal emigration and frustration.” Sánchez writes in a voice of sophisticated cynicism that U.S. and European readers have found irresistible, and she has won accolades from *Time Magazine*, *Foreign Policy*, and Barack Obama in the United States, to *El País* in Spain, for her trenchant critiques of everyday life in Special Period Cuba.

Bush-Era Policies

In 2002 Bush appointed James Cason head of the U.S. Interests Section. Cason took an active role in promoting and supporting opposition groups in Cuba. His activities succeeded in raising the international profile of Cuba’s opposition. But they also contributed to the March, 2003 wave of arrests. The dissident groups had been infiltrated, and were charged under the 1999 Law for the Protection of Cuban National Independence and the Economy (Ley de Protección de la Independencia Nacional y la Economía de Cuba, Ley 88) with accepting gifts and money from Cason and other organizations, and supplying them with information, for the express purpose of overthrowing Cuba’s government.

The trade embargo was loosened in 2000, with the U.S. Congress allowing sales of food and limited amounts of medicine. By 2004 Cuba was the third largest recipient of U.S. food exports, and the United States was Cuba’s largest source.[37] The shelves of the dollar stores were filled with U.S. brands. Just as the U.S. government acquiesced to U.S. farmers’ demands for access to the Cuban market, however, it made it more difficult for Cuban Americans to visit their relatives in Cuba.

In mid-2004, the United States limited family visits to immediate relatives to once every three years, as well as restricting remittances to immediate family members. The Cuban American community was, unsurprisingly, divided about such measures. Some of the older immigrants had few family ties left in Cuba, and their anti-revolutionary politics remained as virulent as ever. To them, restrictions on family visits seemed like good politics. The post-1980, and especially post-